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Social Theory of International Politics

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3 "Ideas all the way down?": on the constitution of power and interest

In post-war scholarship the starting point for most theorizing about international politics has been power and national interest, with power understood ultimately as military capability and interest as an egoistic desire for power, security, or wealth. This is usually identified with a Realist approach to the subject. While conceding the importance of power and interest, in the early 1980s Neoliberals¹ began to argue that international institutions also play a significant role in international politics. Neorealists and Neoliberals disagree about their relative weight, but they would probably agree that together the three factors explain most of the variance in international outcomes. Moreover, although adherents of neither approach tend to call themselves "materialists," both Neorealists and Neoliberals routinely refer to power and interest, and sometimes even institutions, as "material" factors. Against this materialist consensus a number of IR scholars today are emphasizing a fourth factor, "ideas." This focus goes back at least to Snyder, Bruck, and Sapin,² who pioneered a tradition of cognitivist research on the role of belief systems and perceptions in foreign policy decision-making. But it has really taken off in the last decade with multiple lines of theorizing, both mainstream and critical, about identity, ideology, discourse, culture, and, simply, ideas. In other words, materialist assumptions are no longer unproblematic in IR theory, and materialist scholars are facing a resurgent idealism that puts the question of "what difference do ideas make?" clearly on the table.

There are two ways to approach this question, and thus two ways to

¹ Though they were only called this after the fact.

² Snyder, Bruck, and Sapin (1954).

frame the idealism-materialism debate. The dominant approach in mainstream political science is to treat ideas in causal terms as a (typically intervening) "variable" that explains some proportion of behavior beyond the effects of power, interest, and institutions alone. In an influential volume on ideas and foreign policy, for example, editors Judith Goldstein and Robert Keohane define the null hypothesis for the proposition that ideas matter as: "variation in policy across countries, or over time, is entirely accounted for by changes in factors *other than* ideas," by which they mean principally power and interest.³ And in a recent symposium on the role of ideas in American politics, Karen Orren and Theda Skocpol unproblematically juxtapose ideas to institutions as rival causes, and Morris Fiorina does the same with ideas and interests.⁴ In both collections power, interests, and even institutions are treated as idea-free baselines against which the role of ideas is judged.

This causal framing of the materialism-idealism debate gets at important effects. In one sense identity, ideology, and culture *are* distinct from power and interests, and *do* play a causal role in social life.⁵ To explain world politics by reference to the hegemony of liberal ideology *is* different than doing so by reference to state interests. The superstructure *is* different than the base. As such, a causal approach is not "wrong." The problem rather is that it stacks the deck against idealists, largely conceding to materialists the study of war and conflict which seem particularly amenable to power and interest explanations. And theories that treat ideas as intervening or superstructural variables will always be vulnerable to the charge that they are derived from theories that emphasize the base variables of power and interest, merely mopping up unexplained variance.⁶ In my view Neoliberals nevertheless have demonstrated amply the proposition that ideas and institutions are at least relatively autonomous determinants of international life,⁷ which poses an important challenge to "vulgar" materialisms.

In this chapter I focus on a second way to frame the debate, which results in a deeper challenge to materialism. The causal approach

³ Goldstein and Keohane (1993: 6).

⁴ Orren (1995), Skocpol (1995), Fiorina (1995). Of the contributors to the symposium, only Rogers Smith (1995) raises questions about these dualisms, taking a line similar to the one I shall take below.

⁵ Yee (1996). ⁶ Krasner (1983a), Mearsheimer (1994/1995).

⁷ See especially Keohane (1984) and Baldwin, ed. (1993).

avored by Neoliberals assumes that ideas matter only to the extent that they have effects beyond effects of power, interest, and institutions. This second, social constructivist approach inquires into the extent to which ideas *constitute* those ostensibly "material" causes in the first place. To the extent that material causes are *made* of ideas we will not get a full understanding of how ideas matter by treating them as variables distinct from other causes. On this view explanation by reference to power, interests, or institutions cannot be what defines "materialism" at all. Rather, what makes a theory materialist is that it accounts for the effects of power, interests, or institutions by reference to "brute" material forces – things which exist and have certain causal powers independent of ideas, like human nature, the physical environment, and, perhaps, technological artifacts. The constitutive debate between materialists and idealists is not about the relative contribution of ideas versus power and interest to social life. The debate is about the relative contribution of brute material forces to power and interest explanations. Materialists cannot claim power and interest as "their" variables; it all depends on how the latter are constituted.

Note that this interpretation of materialism conflicts with conventional usage, which owes much to Marxism.⁸ Marxism defines the material base as the mode of production, and locates ideology, culture, and other ideational factors in a non-material superstructure. "Materialism" thereby becomes identified with explanations by reference to economic factors. This is easily extended to the military factors of concern to Realists – modes of destruction are as basic as modes of production. Either way, ideational factors are relegated a priori to non-economic, non-military considerations. Building on an argument of Douglas Porpora,⁹ I am suggesting that this way of thinking about materialism and idealism is problematic. The problem is that Marxism defines the mode of production not only in terms of forces but also in terms of *relations* of production. Forces of production ("tools") are plausible candidates for being brute material forces. But relations of production are thoroughly ideational phenomena, namely institutions or rules – which are ultimately shared ideas – that constitute property and exchange relationships, who works for whom, class powers and

interests, and so on. The fact that relations of production are ideational means that capitalism is mostly a *cultural* form, not material, and as such Marxism's "material base" actually is shot through and through with ideas. Apart from the physical bodies of workers and capitalists, the only really material things about a capitalist economy are the forces of production. Indeed, since socialism uses identical forces of production, what constitutes one economy as capitalist and the other as socialist are in fact the relations of production. Rather than define materialism as a focus on the mode of production or destruction, therefore, it makes more sense to define it in terms of a particular hypothesis about these cultural forms. The materialist hypothesis is that the content of cultural forms largely can be explained by the characteristics of brute material forces, whether human nature (as in sociobiology) or technology (as in technological determinism).¹⁰ Whatever cannot be explained in this way would then belong to an idealist account.

Restricting the meaning of materialism in this way is a key rhetorical move in this chapter, which is justified by the fact that the traditional framing of the debate stacks the deck against idealism. Part of what makes the traditional framing attractive is a tendency to conflate "objective" with "material." But the fact that relations of production and destruction consist of shared ideas does not change the fact that they confront actors as objective social facts with real, objective "material" effects. Inequality and exploitation still exist, even if they are constituted by ideas. Indeed, unlike the causal approach to the effect of ideas, which concedes power and interest to materialists but tries to show that they matter less than materialists think, the constitutive approach implies no such claim. At the end of this chapter power and interest will matter just as much as they did before. This raises the question of what is gained by redescribing them in ideational terms? Is this anything more than a philosophical point? Answering in the affirmative is the burden of my argument, but my claim is that the extent to which the "material base" is constituted by ideas is an important question that has been largely ignored in mainstream IR, and one that bears on the transformative potentials of the international system.

In sum, the goal of this chapter is to show that much of the apparent explanatory power of ostensibly "materialist" explanations is actually

⁸ See Little (1991: 114–135).

⁹ Porpora (1993), who in turn draws on Rubinstein (1981). For different framings of the idealism–materialism issue see Mann (1979) and Adler and Borys (1993).

¹⁰ Bimber (1994) is very good on the latter.

constituted by suppressed constructivist assumptions about the content and distribution of ideas. The central thesis is that the meaning of power and the content of interests are largely a function of ideas. (As such only after the ideational conditions of possibility for power and interest explanations have been exposed and stripped out can we assess the effects of materiality *as such*.) In this chapter I focus on the constitution of power and interest only. Institutions are sometimes also seen as material (as in Orren and Skocpol's opposition of institutions to ideas noted above), but this makes little sense once we recognize that objectivity is not exhausted by materiality. Institutions are made of norms and rules, which are ideational phenomena – "shared mental models"¹¹ – and as such, despite being objective social facts, they are firmly on the idealist side of the equation. I defer analysis of institutions to chapter 4 instead.

The argument of the chapter proceeds in two main stages. In the first section I show that the explanatory power of Waltz's materialist theory of structure, the explicit elements of which are anarchy and the distribution of material capabilities, rests on implicit assumptions about the distribution of interests. In the second section I argue that these interests are in turn constituted largely by ideas. Here I play off rational choice theory, which treats ideas only as a means for realizing exogenous interests and thereby supports the presumption that interests are material. I agree that some ideas play such a role, but others constitute interests. In both sections I argue that brute material forces have some effects on the constitution of power and interest, and as such my thesis is not ideas *all the way down* (hence the question mark in the chapter title). My defense of this "rump" materialism is rooted in scientific realism's naturalistic approach to society, described in chapter 2. Rump materialism is an important concession to Political Realism, but as we will see it still leaves most of the action to non-Realists. The two sections together suggest that the most fundamental factor in international politics is the "distribution of ideas" in the system, the structure of which I take up in subsequent chapters.

The constitution of power by interest

The proposition that the nature of international politics is shaped by power relations invariably is listed as one of the defining character-

istics of Realism.¹² This cannot be a *uniquely* Realist claim, however, since then every student of international politics would be a Realist. Neoliberals think power is important, Marxists think power is important, postmodernists even think it is everywhere. The fact that almost everyone today agrees with this basic "Realist" contention might be taken as a measure of Realism's success in getting us to be realistic about the world, but that seems counter-productive. It debases the coinage of Realist theory to assimilate otherwise contradictory views under a single Realist rubric. Realism becomes meaningless or trivial. Better instead to differentiate theories according to *how power is constituted*. From this perspective, the distinctively Realist claim is the materialist hypothesis that the effects of power are constituted primarily by brute material forces. The rival idealist hypothesis is that power is constituted primarily by ideas and cultural contexts.

One of the important virtues of the dominant form of contemporary Realism, Neorealism, is that it is clear (if not entirely explicit) about its materialism. In conceptualizing international structure Waltz makes the distribution of material capabilities the key variable and specifically rejects more social conceptualizations of structure. This clarity distinguishes Neo- from Classical Realism and permits a clear comparison with idealist views. Waltz's emphasis on material capabilities is of course not unprecedented in Realism. Morton Kaplan was among the first to define system structure in terms of the "polarity" of the distribution of power, and Robert Gilpin has been an important exponent of the idea that international systems tend to be dominated by a materially hegemonic Great Power, the rise and fall of which drives systemic evolution.¹³ But it is Waltz who has developed the most systematic conceptualization of international material structure, and is most identified with Neorealism. For that reason I focus on his theory below, although any theory which claims that the effects of power are constituted primarily by brute material forces will be vulnerable to the ensuing argument.

The discussion proceeds in three steps. I first present Waltz's *explicit* model of structure. Although my primary concern here is with the role of the distribution of material power under anarchy, with a view toward possible non-IR readers I take this opportunity to summarize other elements of his theory (with some commentary), which can be recalled in later chapters as they become relevant. I then argue that

¹¹ Denzau and North (1994).

¹² For example, Keohane (1986b: 165).

¹³ Kaplan (1957), Gilpin (1981).

Waltz's explicit model can only explain what it purports to explain by relying on an *implicit* model of the "distribution of interests." Insofar as interests are themselves material this argument does not violate the spirit of Neorealism, and can be seen as a friendly amendment to the theory. On the other hand, to argue there is a distribution of interests also serves a subversive purpose, since later in the chapter I argue that interests are ideas. Finally, having shown that Waltz's hypotheses about material power depend on assumptions about interests/ideas, I remind the reader of my scientific realist premises by defending the rump materialist view that material capabilities do have *some* intrinsic causal powers. It is the relationship of these to interests (and shared ideas or culture) that determine the quality of international life.

Waltz's explicit model: anarchy and the distribution of power

In order to generate predictions a structural theory must make assumptions about the nature of structure, the motivations of agents, and the character of the process that connects them. This is true of all structural theories and Neorealism is no different.

Waltz conceptualizes the nature of structure along three dimensions.¹⁴ *Ordering principles* refer to the principles by which the elements of structure are organized, and in particular whether they stand in relations of equality or super- and subordination. In domestic political systems units are organized hierarchically, with some entitled to command and others obliged to obey. In the contemporary international system the units (states) are sovereign equals, and the ordering principle is therefore anarchic. In the Neorealist view anarchy is a constant, having defined international politics for hundreds if not thousands of years. So even though it is thought to have certain consequences it does not explain variation in outcomes.

The character of the units refers to the functions performed by the system's elements. In domestic political systems units perform different functions; some deal with defense, others with welfare, still others with economic growth. In the international system, states all perform the same functions (internal order, external defense) and so are "like units." States vary in their capabilities and other attributes, but not functionally. Waltz says that units will be homogeneous as long as the system is anarchic (see below), and so this dimension of structure

effectively drops out of his theory, although others have tried to reinstate it by arguing that anarchy is compatible with functional differentiation.¹⁵

Finally, *the distribution of capabilities* refers to the extent to which material power resources (especially economic and military) are concentrated in the system, with those states having significantly disproportionate shares known as poles. Since anarchy is a constant and functional differentiation has dropped out, it is this dimension which constitutes variation in international structure and thereby generates varying outcomes. Although the distribution of capabilities is an aggregate of unit-level attributes, it is a property of the system as a whole with effects that cannot be reduced to the unit-level.¹⁶ Also noteworthy here is Waltz's argument that attributes of states which do not concern material capability, like ideology or bellicosity, as well as the quality of relations between states, like amity or enmity, should not be included in the definition of structure.¹⁷ Drawing an analogy to markets, Waltz's argument is that just as what matters in assessing the structure of a market is only the number and size of firms, so in international politics what matters is only the number and power of states. It is this step in the argument which ultimately makes Waltz's theory of structure materialist.

Waltz concentrates his energy on elaborating this theory of structure and its implications, in part because he is critical of "reductionist" theories of international politics that emphasize domestic politics, the motivations of state agents, or the character of the interaction process among states. While he does not give unit-level variables a significant place in his theory, however, he too makes explicit assumptions about agents and process, without which his theory would not work.

An important goal of Waltz's argument is to show that international structure has certain effects even if states do not intend them. The actual intentions of states do not particularly concern him. His strategy here parallels that of neoclassical economists, who try to avoid making substantial assumptions about actors' psychology by explaining varying outcomes through reference to changing prices in the environment rather than changing preferences.¹⁸ Like economists, however, Waltz has to make *some* assumptions about motivations,

¹⁴ Waltz (1979: 79–101).

¹⁵ Ruggie (1983a), Buzan, Jones, and Little (1993).

¹⁶ Waltz (1979: 97–98).

¹⁷ Ibid.: 98–99.

¹⁸ See especially Stigler and Becker (1977).

since without them his actors would be inert and there would be no movement in the system.¹⁹ He makes two. One is that states are concerned first and foremost with security, since the pursuit of other goals only makes sense once survival is assured.²⁰ This opposes the view of many Classical Realists that states maximize power as an end in itself. The assumption of security-seeking says nothing about states' relationships toward each other as they think about their security, however, and as such is logically compatible with a collective rather than competitive security system. Waltz does not make the point himself, but he makes a second motivational assumption which rules that possibility out: that states are egoistic or "self-regarding."²¹ Combine this assumption with anarchy, and "[s]tates [will] not enjoy even an imperfect guarantee of their own security unless they set out to provide it for themselves,"²² which means the international system is by definition a "self-help" system.

Waltz's discussion of the process through which state agents and system structures relate is even more marginal in the text than his treatment of state motivations. In fact, the term "process" plays a largely pejorative role in Neorealist discourse because it seems to oppose "structural" theorizing. (Waltz argues that structure relates to agents by affecting their behavior "indirectly," through two processes, competition and socialization.²³) However, the centrality of these processes to his theory raises doubts that international structure can be thought of in strict materialist terms, and Waltz must render considerably narrow conceptualizations of both, making them as mechanistic and unsocial as possible.

Competition selects outcomes according to their consequences. Actors whose behavior conforms with the incentives in a structure will prosper, whether or not they intend to do so, while others will not. Although Waltz's preferred analogy is to micro-economics, the selection metaphor also suggests an analogy to sociobiology, which aspires quite explicitly to a materialist analysis of social life.²⁴ The analogy is not perfect, since there is some ambiguity about whether the object of selection in Waltz's model is behavior or the actors

¹⁹ On the necessity for any structural theory to make assumptions about motivation see Emmett (1976).

²⁰ Waltz (1979: 126). ²¹ Ibid.: 91. ²² Waltz (1959: 201).

²³ Waltz (1979: 74–77).

²⁴ On the relationship between economics and sociobiology see Hirshleifer (1978), and Witt (1985).

themselves.²⁵ Only the second is compatible with the meaning of selection in Darwinian theory. While Waltz does argue that competition helps produce like units, he concentrates mostly on selection of behavior. This is a problem for sociobiologists because behavioral tendencies can be selected through social learning, a "Lamarckian" or cultural mechanism at odds with the Darwinian's materialist emphasis on genetic inheritance.²⁶ I address these problems in chapter 7. What matters here is that the selection metaphor is more compatible with a materialist view of structure if it is limited to selection of units rather than selection of behavior.

This is even more true of socialization. At first glance the fact that Waltz discusses socialization at all is surprising. There is little that is "social" about his theory, least of all his conceptualization of what states are presumably being socialized to, namely "structure." Materialists in economics and sociobiology are not known for emphasizing socialization; its home is with idealists in sociology and social psychology. The anomaly disappears, however, when we consider the way in which Waltz treats the concept.

As with selection, socialization can have two distinct objects, behavior and attributes or properties. While acknowledging both possibilities,²⁷ Waltz focuses almost entirely on behavior. This is not surprising: it allows him to acknowledge the existence of norms and rules, which is necessary for any meaningful theory of socialization, but by treating them as patterns of behavior rather than as shared ideas he does not have to give up materialism.²⁸ Yet this behaviorism comes at a cost. Reducing norms and rules to patterned behavior makes it difficult to distinguish behavior that is norm-governed from behavior which is not, and this undermines the point of talking about norms, rules, and thus socialization in the first place. Dogs engage in patterned behavior, but we do not call it norm-governed nor its result a society. Why do so with the patterned behavior of states? Calling the production of behavioral conformity "socialization" says little if the structure that actors are being socialized to has no "social" content. Waltz does refer at least once to the international system as a "society,"²⁹ but if his failure to invoke Bull's

²⁵ McKeown (1986: 53).

²⁶ Boyd and Richerson (1985).

²⁷ Waltz (1979: 76).

²⁸ It also raises some interesting questions about the relationship between materialism and behavioral IR scholarship that I cannot explore here.

²⁹ Waltz (1986: 326).

distinction between system and society is any indication, he does not see this as significant for the nature of structure. Indeed, a key goal of Neorealist scholarship over the past two decades has been to show that social factors are *not* important in world politics, which may account for the fact that most Neorealists avoid talk of socialization altogether.³⁰

This avoidance becomes even more understandable if we consider the possibility of a socialization process affecting the properties of states and not just their behavior. There are two types of attributes potentially at stake, material and ideational. To argue that socialization affects the former would be to argue that material structure is shaped by process, which Neorealism rejects. And to argue that it affects ideational attributes raises the question of what kind of structure those ideas would constitute in the aggregate if not a *social* structure, defined not merely as patterned behavior but as shared understandings. Neorealism also rejects this. On both scores, in other words, the possibility that socialization might change state properties would challenge a purely materialist view of structure. Waltz is forced to limit socialization to behavioral conditioning, but that gives him a second mechanism by which structure affects outcomes, without requiring him to conceptualize structure in social terms. This is not to deny that socialization may sometimes change only behavior, but if this is *all* it can do then the concept loses much of its significance.

Waltz's theory suggests at least four hypotheses, which subsequent Neorealist scholarship has clustered around. Perhaps the most important is that states will tend to balance each other's power.³¹ In an anarchy there is no Leviathan that states can count on for security, nor can they count on each other unless it is in others' self-interest. In such a world the best way to ensure survival is to deter aggression by matching the capabilities of one's rivals, either by building up one's own power ("internal" balancing) or, if this is not enough, by recruiting allies ("external" balancing).

Another prediction is that states will tend to be concerned more with relative than absolute gains, and will therefore find it difficult to cooperate.³² Even in domestic politics collective action is difficult in the absence of coercion or selective incentives because of the problem of free riding. However, in an anarchy actors must also worry that

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others will gain more from cooperation than they do, since those relative gains might be turned later on into military advantage. The fear of relative loss may make no cooperation preferable to some.

A third hypothesis is that states will tend to become "like units." There is some ambiguity in Waltz's discussion here, since he argues that international systems are created by the co-action of units that are *already* functionally equivalent and self-regarding, which would seem to suggest that their similarity cannot be effects of the system. However, it is not difficult to modify Waltz's presentation in light of a Darwinian perspective, such that in an anarchic environment, actors which lack a capacity for organized violence will tend to "die out" in the competition with actors which do have that capacity, i.e. states. (Whether such an argument can actually explain the evolution of the international system is another matter.)³³

Finally, Waltz argues that bipolar systems have intrinsic advantages over multipolar ones.³⁴ In a bipolar world the important states are less likely to miscalculate their relative power position because there is less uncertainty about potential threats, and so are less likely to initiate wars by mistake. The poles will also be more self-sufficient, which reduces their vulnerability to the whims of others. And two poles will find it easier to cooperate in managing the world's common problems than will many. These advantages do not mean bipolarity will tend to replace multipolarity over time, since the distribution of power is driven largely by unit-level factors that have little to do with international structure,³⁵ but they do sound an important cautionary note about the celebration surrounding the end of the Cold War and collapse of the Soviet Union.³⁶

Waltz's implicit model: the distribution of interests

On the surface it looks as if most of the explanatory work in Neorealism is done by anarchy and the distribution of power. Anarchies seem to be inherently competitive systems the logic of which states ignore at their peril, and the number and size of major powers seem to be the key factors for states when considering threats to their security. Yet if we look deeper it becomes apparent that much of the work is in fact being done by factors only implicit in the model.

³⁰ Cf. Ikenberry and Kupchan (1990).

³¹ Waltz (1979: 102–128).

³² See especially Grieco (1988, 1990).

³³ See Spruyt (1994) and chapter 7 below.

³⁴ Waltz (1979: 161–210).

³⁵ See Gilpin (1981).

³⁶ Mearsheimer (1990a, b).

There are two ways to develop such an argument. For now I focus on the distribution of interests in the system, a level of ideational structure that is dealt with by both Neoliberals and constructivists. Drawing on work carried out independently by Andrew Moravcsik, Randall Schweller, and Arthur Stein, as well as on my own previous efforts to conceptualize the role of the "structure of identity and interest" in international politics, I argue that Waltz's conclusions depend on the "distribution of interests" (the phrase is Stein's) in the system.³⁷ Note that this does not call Realism into question as long as those interests are in turn constituted by material forces. Later in this chapter I argue that interests are in fact ideas, which does problematize Realism.

The other way to make the argument would be to identify *cultural* formations at the systemic level – shared ideas making up norms, institutions, threat-systems, and so on – that constitute the meaning of the distribution of power, either by constituting states' perceptions of that distribution or by constituting their identities and interests. That shared ideas play such a role is of course a central thesis of this book, and throughout this chapter the reader should keep in mind that "culture" lurks just behind "interest." In chapters 4 and 6 I discuss the role and effects of system-level cultural structures and relate them to the interest-constituting ideas discussed in this chapter.

The implicit role of the distribution of interests in Waltz's theory can be seen if we vary his two assumptions that states are egoists who are motivated primarily by security. Consider first the possibility that security is *not* states' top priority, which has been raised by Schweller. There is no dispute that states want to *survive*; this much is trivially true. By "security-seeking" Waltz means something more: that states want to preserve what they already have rather than try to get more, for example by conquering other states or changing the rules of the system. This does not follow from wanting to survive. After all, what if one can survive *and* conquer others? Or what if one believes the only way *to* survive is by doing so? Schweller argues that by assuming that states are security-seeking Waltz is tacitly assuming they are satisfied or "status quo" powers. For status quo states the accumulation of power is a means rather than an end, which will stop when security needs are met. An alternative assumption would be that states are "revisionists," out to grab territory, conquer each other, or change the rules of the system. For these states no amount of power is

³⁷ Moravcsik (1997), Schweller (1993, 1994), Stein (1990), and Wendt (1992).

too much, its accumulation is more an end in itself. This was an important theme for Classical Realists like Hans Morgenthau, who thought that human nature contained a will to power or "animus dominandi" that provided a constant well-spring for revisionism.³⁸ Waltz wants to get away from such a dubious psychology, but rather than leave psychology behind he simply substitutes a different one. Morgenthau's states are by nature aggressive and opportunistic, Waltz's defensive and cautious.³⁹

Assumptions about motivation are necessary even in the most structural of theories, and so pointing out that Waltz makes them is not a criticism. The criticism is that he does not make clear that his conclusions about the effects of anarchy and the distribution of power *depend* on those assumptions. An anarchy of status quo powers will be a relatively stable world in which states generally respect each other's territorial property rights and are not looking for a fight. Live and let live will be the operative rule. Even weak states will thrive in such an environment because others do not want to conquer them, and as a result states will have a low overall "death rate."⁴⁰ Status quo states may still get into security dilemmas,⁴¹ in which uncertainty about others' intentions causes arms races that sometimes lead to war, but this is the exception rather than the norm. In other words, states with status quo interests constitute one *kind* of anarchy. Compare this to an anarchy constituted by states with revisionist interests. In this world states will try to conquer each other, territorial property rights will not be recognized, and weak states will have a high death rate. Rather than balance, revisionists will "bandwagon" in aggressive coalitions that maximize their chances of changing the system.⁴² Status quo states may deter them, but in general an anarchy of revisionist states will be much less stable than an anarchy of status quo states. As states in the two systems look out on the world, therefore, the *meaning* that anarchy and the distribution of capabilities have for them will be quite different.

Now vary Waltz's other motivational assumption, that states are egoists about their security. We all sometimes do things that have no instrumental benefit for ourselves: giving to charity, tipping a waiter

³⁸ Morgenthau (1946: 192).

³⁹ This difference underlies the contemporary debate between "offensive" and "defensive" Realists; see, for example, Zakaria (1998: 18–41).

⁴⁰ Waltz (1979: 137).

⁴¹ Herz (1950), Jervis (1978); cf. Schweller (1996).

⁴² Schweller (1994).

in a foreign city, helping a stranger, voting in elections, even sacrificing our lives in war. These actions are usually situation-specific and as such do not imply that we are always or intrinsically altruistic. However, they do involve some degree of identification with the welfare of others, which cannot be explained by any non-tautological concept of self-interest.⁴³ What is needed is a way to think about collective identity. This might seem irrelevant to international politics, since states are hardly known for their altruism, although I argue later that states have much more collective identity than is usually thought. But in order to even raise the question, we need to first see that such a motivation is logically possible, and that it implies a different logic of anarchy.

Specifically, in an international system where states possess substantial collective identity, it is unlikely that they will feel their security depends on balancing each other's military power. As Stephen Walt argues, states balance against threats not power, and as long as states are confident that others identify with their security they will not see each other as military threats.⁴⁴ Admittedly such confidence is hard to come by, but it is possible. It seems doubtful that Canada is much worried these days about American threats to its security, or Britain about French threats. Instead of balancing, states that have achieved this level of mutual identification are more likely to secure themselves by observing the rule of law in settling their disputes, and by practicing collective security when threatened from outside, which is a kind of bandwagoning based on the principle of "all for one, one for all." This is not a self-help system in any interesting sense, since the self has become the collective.⁴⁵

None of this is to deny that modern states are status quo egoists. Indeed, they might be mostly just that. Nor is it to argue that the logic of anarchy, and the distribution of interests that constitutes it, can be changed (though I later argue that it sometimes can). The claim is only that the effects of anarchy and material structure depend on what states *want*.⁴⁶ The logic of anarchy among revisionist states takes the form of a fight to the death; among status quo states, arms racing and some brawls; among collectivist states, perhaps heated but ultimately non-violent arguments about burden sharing. Game theory teaches us

⁴³ See Jencks (1990) and chapter 5, pp. 238–243.

⁴⁴ Walt (1987).

⁴⁵ Although this collectivism may be specific to military security, self-help might still rule in other issue-areas.

⁴⁶ Moravcsik (1997).

the same lesson: the configuration of preferences drives outcomes. The distribution of power matters, but *how* it matters, the *meaning* it has for actors, depends on what game they are playing. Bipolarity among friends is one thing, among enemies quite another. The one might be an "Assurance Game," the other "Deadlock."

It is important to note that this discussion of interests does not compromise the "systemic" nature of the argument. This is an argument about the distribution of interests in the system, not about the foreign policy preferences and choices of individual states. Different distributions of interests in populations⁴⁷ of states will generate different logics of anarchy. A collectivist in a system of revisionists is likely to do poorly, but so will a revisionist in one of collectivists. It is true that the distribution of interests is made up of unit-level properties, but so is the distribution of material capabilities. Both are systemic phenomena because their effects cannot be reduced to the unit-level. In sum, Waltz has done more than make an assumption about the motivations of individual states, who then interact with an independently existing material structure. He has made an assumption about the distribution of interests in the system as a whole, and in so doing he has added to his theory of structure two things which he says do not belong there: non-capability attributes (egoistic motivations), and the quality of relations among units (self-help). He has in other words made an implicit assumption about the *social* structure of international politics (leaving aside for now whether it has a material or ideational basis). This does not make his theory of structure wrong, just underspecified. Making the distribution of interests an explicit dimension of structure would take care of the problem.

Even if they might accept the distribution of interests as an important systemic phenomenon, however, Neorealists might argue that it can be derived from other elements of Waltz's model and so does not require independent analysis. The reason has to do with the problem of uncertainty about other states' intentions. People can never be 100 per cent certain about each other's intentions because they cannot read minds and minds can always change. This "Problem of Other Minds"⁴⁸ is particularly acute for states because of the relatively low level of institutionalization in the international system,

⁴⁷ "Population" is plural here because the international system may contain relatively autonomous sub-systems or "security complexes" (Buzan, 1991), with their own distributions of interests and logics of anarchy.

⁴⁸ Hollis and Smith (1990: 171–176).

which means that states have even less information to go on than actors do in domestic politics, and because of the danger of being wrong in their assessments, which could be fatal. In such a world it might be argued that prudent states will assume the worst about others' intentions, which means basing their interests on the possibilities inherent in the distribution of capabilities, rather than on the probabilities that others might be benign.⁴⁹ On this argument, in other words, what states want will be based on worst-case assumptions about the distribution of power. This already figures in Waltz's model and so the distribution of interests would drop out.

This argument has the form of a "self-fulfilling prophecy," and I will argue in chapter 4 that culture is a self-fulfilling prophecy.⁵⁰ Actors act on the basis of beliefs they have about their environment and others, which tends to reproduce those beliefs. The self-fulfilling prophecy idea can explain a great deal about the production and reproduction of social life.

However, the fact that cultures tend to be stable or sticky cannot do the work here of eliminating an independent structural role for the distribution of interests, because history also matters. If states really did know nothing about each other's minds, and if they really would get killed by a single mistaken inference, then it may be rational to assume the worst and focus only on the distribution of capabilities. Such conditions sometimes occur, as in "First Encounters" between alien peoples, and as a thought-experiment they are useful. But in real world international politics they are not the norm. Contemporary states have been interacting for dozens, even hundreds of years, during which they have accumulated considerable knowledge about each other's interests. They know something about each other's grievances and ambitions, and thus about whether they are status quo or revisionist states. They know something about each other's styles of dispute resolution. And they even know something about the conditions under which these conditions might change. None of this knowledge is perfect or complete, but neither is it wholly unreliable or irrelevant. Part of what makes it reliable is experience: over the course of their interactions states have made policies on the basis of inferences about each other's intentions (pessimistic or optimistic), which were then tested and revised against the reality of what those intentions really were. Through this process of interacting with reality,

⁴⁹ On the consequences of this assumption see Brooks (1997).

⁵⁰ See Kukla (1994).

states have learned a great deal about each other, and today can often assign reasonably confident probabilities to inferences about what others want. Would it be rational for states to forego this knowledge because it is merely probabilistic, and instead make judgements based solely on worst-case, possibilistic reasoning? Would it be rational today for Canada to assume the worst about American intentions? Or even France about German ones? Not in my view. States will always be prudent, and sometimes worst-case assumptions are warranted, but prudence does not mean they will (or should) throw experience to the wind. History matters. And since that history is based in part on what others' interests really are, the distribution of interests must have an independent role in constituting the meaning of anarchy and the distribution of power.

Toward a rump materialism I

The explanatory significance of the distribution of power depends on historically contingent distributions of state interests. If interests and culture plausibly can be treated as given and constant – and in relatively stable cultural structures like the Cold War this may be the case – then variation in the distribution of capabilities may explain a great deal. Still this does not reduce the importance of interests and culture in making those explanations possible in the first place. We might say, then, that Neorealism "fetishizes" material capabilities in the sense that it imbues them with meanings and powers that "can only correctly be attributed to human beings."⁵¹ But to say this is not to deny the importance of the distribution of capabilities, since my argument has been that assumptions about interests (and, I will argue, systemic culture) have been implicit in Waltz's model all along. *Given* states with egoistic, status quo interests interacting in a "market-like" culture, Waltz's hypotheses about anarchy or bipolarity may hold. In this respect my argument is unlike Neoliberalism, which seeks to show that the distribution of power is less important than Neorealism claims because ideas and institutions explain much of the variance instead. I am not juxtaposing interest as a rival explanation to power, nor claiming that interests *cause* power to have certain effects. I am saying that power only explains what it explains insofar as it is given meaning by interest. The argument is constitutive, not causal.

⁵¹ Dant (1996: 496).

Having criticized a vulgar or reductionist materialism, however, I now want to defend a "rump" materialism which opposes the more radical constructivist view that brute material forces have *no* independent effects on international politics. It may seem unnecessary to undertake such a defense, since it is difficult to find any IR scholar who explicitly endorses such a radical view. Yet, given the almost complete absence of discussion in most postmodern IR scholarship of material forces as independent constraints on state action it is difficult not to conclude that it is at least a connotation, if not a denotation, of this literature that international life is ideas *all* the way down. In my view it cannot be ideas all the way down because scientific realism shows that ideas are based on and are regulated by an independently existing physical reality. As John Searle puts it, brute facts have ontological priority over institutional facts.⁵² Perhaps it is unfair to attribute to postmodernism a denial of this belief, even as only a connotation. The following discussion would then really be superfluous – although in that case there should also be relatively little disagreement with what follows. But given the ease with which a moderate constructivism can be tarred with the brush of implausible radical positions,⁵³ it seems useful to consider the point explicitly. Brute material forces have independent effects on international life in at least three ways.

1 The distribution of actors' material capabilities affects the possibility and likelihood of certain outcomes. Militarily weak states typically cannot conquer powerful ones, powerful states typically can conquer weak states, and a balance of military power makes any conquest difficult. This is the core insight of Neorealism. The fact that in the absence of a willingness to use those capabilities these effects would not be activated does not change the fact that, when activated by human purpose, the distribution of capabilities has independent effects on outcomes. If a weak state attempts to conquer a strong state it will encounter these effects.

2 The "composition" of material capabilities,⁵⁴ and in particular the character of the technology they embody, has similar constraining and enabling effects. The technological ability to interact over long dis-

tances makes international systems possible in the first place.⁵⁵ Armies with tanks will usually defeat armies with spears. Muskets can penetrate chainmail but not shoot across oceans. The balance of offensive and defensive military technology in an era affects the incentives for aggressive war.⁵⁶ The possession of nuclear weapons with second-strike invulnerability makes nuclear war less likely.⁵⁷ And so on. It might be argued that technology is not a "brute" material capability, since it is created by purposeful agents and embodies the state of their technical knowledge (ideas) at that time. To be sure. But once in existence a technological artifact has intrinsic material capacities and it makes possible further technological developments. Whether those capacities are ever used or developments ever realized depends on what actors want and believe, but this does not change the fact that the character of existing technology makes a difference in social life. A stripped down technological determinism – i.e., one that does not include *relations* of production or destruction – is compatible with the kind of social constructivism I have in mind.⁵⁸

3 And then there are geography and natural resources. The distribution of certain metals in a given area makes possible the technological development of primitive societies living there. Inhospitable living conditions discourage settlement. Weather patterns affect agriculture. In turn, human actions may have unintended consequences for the natural environment that feed back on society, with potentially devastating effect (global warming; ozone and resource depletion). Constructivism should not proceed "as if nature did not matter."⁵⁹

Even when properly stripped of their social content, in other words, brute material forces – the true "material base" – can still have independent effects, defining "for all actors the outer limits of feasible activity and the relative costs of pursuing various options that require physical activity."⁶⁰ These effects interact with interests and culture to dispose social action and systems in certain directions and not others. The term "interaction" is significant here, since it means that at some level material forces are constituted independent of society, and affect society in a *causal* way. Material forces are not constituted solely by social meanings,⁶¹ and social meanings are not immune to material

⁵² Searle (1995: 55–56). ⁵³ For example, Mearsheimer (1994/1995).

⁵⁴ The term is Deudney's (1993).

⁵⁵ Buzan and Little (1994). ⁵⁶ Jervis (1978). ⁵⁷ Waltz (1990).

⁵⁸ See especially Bimber (1994). ⁵⁹ Murphy (1995). ⁶⁰ Peterson (1997: 12).

⁶¹ Freudenberg, Frickel, and Gramling (1995).

effects. On the other hand, it is only because of their interaction with ideas that material forces have the effects that they do; the material fact that Germany has more military power than Denmark imposes physical limits on Danish foreign policy toward Germany, but those limits will be irrelevant to their interaction if neither could contemplate war with the other. So the relationship between material forces and ideas works both ways, but we can only properly theorize this relationship if we recognize that at some level they are constituted as different kinds of independently existing stuff. This formulation of the materialism-idealism problem is ultimately Cartesian, insofar as it separates the world into two kinds of phenomena – in effect, mind and body – and may be criticized for that reason. But I do not see any other way to think about the problem if we are to be scientific realists about social life.

It might be objected that material constraints can be eliminated over time by human intervention, so that in the long run it is ideas all the way down. We can change the distribution of power by building military capabilities; we can change the composition of power by creating new technologies; and with these we can change geographical and resource constraints. This argument could extend all the way down to human nature, since humans someday may be able to change their nature through genetic engineering. From this perspective it looks like everything is endogenous to interest and culture, in which case even a “rump” materialism concedes too much theoretically, and in so doing disempowers us politically.

Our on-going and often successful effort to transcend the material constraints facing us is one of the distinctive features of the human condition, and it is clear that interests and culture give that effort impetus and direction. To that extent the effects of material forces are internal to society rather than externally given by nature. However, there are two senses in which I believe a rump materialism still holds. First, it is an open empirical question how much human beings will be able to transcend material constraints. We have certainly come a long way, and it may even be that we are becoming progressively less constrained over time by our material condition, but this does not guarantee that material constraints are infinitely malleable. Indeed, if the increasing negative externalities of technological evolution are any indication, we may be nearing significant absolute constraints now. Nature yields control only grudgingly, which an ideas “all” the way down perspective has difficulty comprehending. Second, even if in

the fullness of time all material constraints are negotiable, in the meantime they are not. Whether we like it or not, the distribution and composition of material capabilities at any given moment help define the possibilities of our action. We can ignore those effects, like the Balinese marching into Dutch machine guns or the Polish cavalry charging German tanks, but we do so at our own risk. Radical constructivism reminds us to historicize what counts as a material constraint, but we should not neglect the synchronic question of how it constrains us in the here and now.

Even though a rump materialism may be too much for some, my main goal in this section has been to show that Neorealist attempts to explain international politics by reference to anarchy and material capabilities alone presuppose much more than this, and in particular the animating force of *purpose*. Ultimately it is our ambitions, fears, and hopes – the things we want material forces *for* – that drive social evolution, not material forces as such. Adding the distribution of interests to Waltz’s theory is one way to capture this fact. Since an emphasis on interests is not inimical to Realism, this could be taken as a friendly amendment.

I now take the argument further. In the rest of this chapter I argue that when IR scholars explain state action by reference to interests, they are actually explaining it by reference to a certain kind of *idea*. If so, the concept of interest will be best explicated within an idealist ontology, and my amendment to Neorealism will prove to have been not so friendly after all.

The constitution of interests by ideas

If an emphasis on the role of power is usually seen as one of the defining features of Realism, then an emphasis on egoistic national interests would be the other. Realists of all stripes believe that states do what they do because it is in their national interest, and that the national interest is self-regarding with respect to security. As with power, however, these cannot be *uniquely* Realist claims, since then almost every IR scholar would be a Realist. No one denies that states act on the basis of perceived interests,⁶² and few would deny that those interests are often egoistic. I certainly do not. To that extent I am

⁶² Except perhaps post-structuralists, for whom the whole notion of intentional action is problematic.

a Realist, but interests should not be seen as an exclusively "Realist" variable. What matters is how interests are thought to be constituted.

As I see it, the uniquely Realist hypothesis about national interests is that they have a material rather than social basis, being rooted in some combination of human nature, anarchy, and/or brute material capabilities. The argument in the preceding section was largely agnostic about this question. It acknowledged that material forces constrain and enable social forms at the margin, but its primary claim was that the distribution of interests helps constitute the meaning of power. Nevertheless, it is widely thought in IR that power and interest are both "material," and therefore that the only way to challenge theories which emphasize them, like Realism, is to show that factors like ideas, norms, or institutions explain a lot of behavior. This has been the intuition behind Neoliberalism, which frames the explanatory problem as power and interest versus institutions, versus norms, versus ideas. This framing has been fruitful, since there is much in international politics that power and interest cannot explain. On the other hand, this view implicitly suggests that power and interest are not themselves constituted by ideas. And since Realists have already claimed power and interest as "their" variables, this limits a priori the role of ideas – and thus non-Realist theories – to the superstructure, and thereby privileges Realist arguments about the base.

Neoliberalism focuses on the ways in which ideas can have causal effects independent of other causes like power and interest. However, ideas also have constitutive effects, on power and interest themselves. Here I discuss how ideas constitute interests. If in some sense interests *are* ideas, then the causal, "ideas-versus-interests" model will be incomplete. This does not mean that all ideas are interests. Most are not. Nor does it mean that interests no longer have an independent explanatory role. They explain just as much as they did before, and exist independently of ideas that do not constitute them, as required by causal explanations. The claim is only that among the different kinds of ideas are some that constitute interests, and that the explanatory power of these ideas therefore cannot be compared to interests as competing causal variables.

To say interests are ideas brings us again to the definition of materialism. I argued above that meaningful power is constituted in important part through the distribution of interests. Here I argue that only a small part of what constitutes interests is actually

material. The material force constituting interests is human nature. The rest is ideational: schemas and deliberations that are in turn constituted by shared ideas or culture. As in my discussion of power-explanations, in other words, my goal here is not to show that interests do not matter, but to show how little of them a properly specified materialism can explain, and to claim the rest for idealism.

Rational choice theory is the conventional framework in mainstream IR for thinking about the relationship between ideas and interests. For that reason I shall organize my discussion with reference to it. The core of rationalist explanations is the view that preferences and expectations generate behavior. This is known in philosophical literature as the equation, "desire plus belief equals action." It is not hard to see how this equation might encourage the interests "versus" ideas thinking that I'm arguing is problematic, and as such play into the materialist bias in IR theory. Rationalism treats desire (or preference or interest) and belief (or expectations or ideas) as distinct variables, which suggests that desires do not depend on beliefs and are therefore material. This connotation is further enabled by the fact that rationalists do not usually ask where interests come from. It is in this way that methodology can become tacit ontology. By the same token, however, strictly speaking the theory is agnostic about that question. Interests might be material or ideational; it simply does not say. Moreover, rationalism has a strong subjectivist aspect, which has led some people to emphasize its affinities to interpretive social science and thus, implicitly, an idealist ontology.⁶³ These considerations suggest rational choice theory might be compatible with an idealist view of interests. Thus, in what follows I shall not be arguing "against" rational choice theory (nor, it might be noted, will I bring up some familiar, long-standing criticisms, such as about the theory's realism); on the contrary – I see it as part of my own understanding of agency (see chapter 7). But it is only part of the story and as such must be assimilated into a constructivist framework. In what follows I first discuss the standard rationalist view of the relationship between interests and ideas, and then propose an alternative.

⁶³ See Ferejohn (1991), Esser (1993); cf. Srubar (1993).

*The rationalist model of man*⁶⁴

Rationalism has both a macro- and micro-dimension. The macro-dimension is concerned with explaining broad patterns of behavior and aggregate outcomes rather than the behavior of individual agents. Often the patterns and outcomes arise via unintended consequences of behavior. What matters here are the structural constraints on choice rather than individual psychology, since the same aggregate outcome may be realizable under various psychological conditions.⁶⁵ While this might suggest that rational choice theory does not depend on assumptions about agents, in fact it does. Even if a macro-outcome is compatible with a variety of desires and beliefs, rationalist explanations presuppose that agents act at least "as if" they are maximizing certain desires and beliefs (see below). The macro level is important and it relates to arguments about the role of culture in constituting interests that I develop in chapter 4, but since my concern in this chapter is only with the nature of interests, I shall limit my discussion here to its micro-aspect, focusing on the logic of desire/belief explanation and the assumptions about human agency which it makes.

To explain action as a product of desire and belief is to offer an "intentional" explanation.⁶⁶ This is the kind of explanation most of us would intuitively give if asked to explain why we went to the grocery store: we had a desire for food and a belief that that desire could be satisfied there. This combination of desire and belief was the "reason" we went to the store, and in the intentionalist view reasons are causes of behavior.⁶⁷ In effect, the intentional theory of action is a dressed up version of the folk psychology implicit in our everyday explanations of behavior.⁶⁸ In the social sciences it has received its most systematic use in economics, however, and is now often seen as the core of an "economic" approach to human behavior, from where it has been

⁶⁴ That it may be a model of *man* is an important issue that I shall pass over here. For a feminist critique of rationalism see England and Kilbourne (1990).

⁶⁵ Satz and Ferejohn (1994).

⁶⁶ See Elster (1983a: 69–88) and Dennett (1987). The terms "desire" and "belief" are conventional in the philosophical literature, but no particular importance attaches to them. The former I take to be equivalent to the social scientist's "interest," "taste," or "preference," while the latter is equivalent to "expectations," "information," or "knowledge."

⁶⁷ Davidson (1963). ⁶⁸ Bilmes (1986: 187).

colonizing other social sciences.⁶⁹ Alexander Rosenberg offers a good summary:

Economics is an intentional science. It holds that economic behavior is determined by tastes and beliefs, that is, by the desire to maximize preferences, subject to the constraint of expectations about available alternatives. Differences between the choices made by individual agents who face the same alternatives are due either to differences in preferences, to differences in expectations, or to both. Similarly, changes in the choices of an individual agent over time are due to changes in one or both of these causal determinants of his behavior.⁷⁰

It is important to note that this explanatory logic says nothing about the *content* of desires and beliefs. This can be seen by distinguishing "thin" and "thick" versions of rational choice theory.⁷¹

The thin theory consists of propositions about the nature of desire and belief and their relationship – in short, intentional explanation as such. In the intentional theory of action the concept of desire refers to a motivation that moves the body in the direction of the object of desire. Desire is always *for* something, and as such plays an active explanatory role in the sense that it is the force or energy which moves the body. This force is activated only if an actor also believes the object of desire can be attained by acting, and so desire by itself is not sufficient to explain action, but given appropriate beliefs the energy for activity comes from desire. Belief plays a more passive explanatory role in the thin theory. Whereas desire is *for* things, belief is *about* them.⁷² Two kinds of beliefs are important: beliefs about states of the external world, and beliefs about the efficacy of different means to satisfy desires in that world. It does not matter whether these beliefs are accurate, only that actors take them to be true. A key assumption of the traditional rationalist model is that beliefs have no motivational force of their own; they merely describe the world. This creates within the model an explanatory bias in favor of desire/interest, which is deeply rooted in the intellectual history of rationalism, going back to Hobbes and Hume.⁷³ Beliefs play an important enabling role in

⁶⁹ In fact, the "economic" approach to behavior also makes assumptions about the content of desire and belief that go beyond the logic of intentional explanation per se; in Ferejohn's (1991) terms below, it involves a "thick" rather than merely "thin" theory of rational choice. On "economic imperialism" see Hirshleifer (1985) and Radnitsky and Bernholz, eds. (1986).

⁷⁰ Rosenberg (1985: 50); cf. Elster (1983b: 2–25).

⁷¹ Ferejohn (1991: 282).

⁷² Schueler (1995: 125).

⁷³ Hollis (1987: 63).

behavior by activating and facilitating the realization of desires, but the active, primary explanatory work is done by desire.

Thick versions of rational choice theory add to this skeleton assumptions about the content of desires and beliefs. One of the most common thick theories is that actors are egoists with complete information about their environment, but thick rationalist theories could alternatively assume altruism and incomplete information. There is no one thick theory of rational choice, and so we need more than the thin theory. Many disagreements in IR scholarship are rooted in different thick theories of human nature and/or the national interest.⁷⁴ Classical Realists offer varying permutations of fear, power, glory, and wealth as candidates. The debate in Neorealism about whether states are status quo or revisionist is in part about whether they are motivated more by fear or power. The debate between Neorealists and Neoliberals about the extent to which states seek relative or absolute gains is in part about whether states are more interested in security or wealth. The question of whether states are capable of collective security depends on whether they are necessarily selfish or capable of having collective interests. And so on. These are important disagreements, but all sides seem to accept the key rationalist premise that desire (the national interest) causes states to act in certain ways.

The intentional equation is also a common baseline in recent IR work on beliefs. One stream of scholarship has focused on the belief systems and perceptions of decision-makers.⁷⁵ This work presents a challenge to thick rationalist theories that assume complete information, but it does not threaten the thin theory.⁷⁶ And there is also recent rationalist work on the role of ideas in foreign policy.⁷⁷ Goldstein and Keohane actually contrast this work to the "rationalist" concern with interests,⁷⁸ but it should be clear from the foregoing discussion that beliefs play an essential role in rationalist theory. In the past rationalist scholars may have neglected belief in favor of desire (usually by assuming that actors have complete information), which encouraged the view that rational choice theory is a materialist theory. Goldstein and Keohane have issued an important reminder that it need not be seen this way. But in itself a focus on ideas poses no inherent threat to rational choice theory's explanatory logic. Most of

⁷⁴ See Smith (1983). ⁷⁵ For example, Jervis (1976), Little and Smith, eds. (1988).

⁷⁶ Cf. Lebow and Stein (1989), Wagner (1992).

⁷⁷ For example, Goldstein (1993), Goldstein and Keohane, eds. (1993).

⁷⁸ Goldstein and Keohane (1993: 4).

the recent mainstream IR scholarship on ideas is clearly based on an intentional theory of action: treating desire and belief as if they were distinct, with the latter relating to the former in instrumental rather than constitutive terms.

Of course, to some extent desire and belief *are* distinct phenomena. Desire is "for," belief "about." The one is motivation, the other cognition. An interesting way to think about the difference is that they have different "directions of fit" with the world.⁷⁹ Desire aims to fit the world to the mind, belief aims to fit the mind to the world. However, this difference does not rule out the possibility that desire may itself be a kind of belief – a belief not about the world, but a belief *that something is desirable*.⁸⁰ I explore below the possibility that cognitive factors constitute desire.

This raises the crucial question of "what is desire (interest)?" The received view, going back at least to Hume, is that desire is constitutionally unrelated to belief. Desire is a matter of passion, not cognition; and while beliefs activate and channel desires, they cannot be desires. Hume's view is "dualistic" in that it explains action by reference to two unrelated mechanisms. This view has two important theoretical consequences. First, if desires are not a function of belief, then it is natural to treat them in materialist fashion as material, and to treat ideas in rationalist fashion as a means for realizing exogenously given interests. Second, the Humean view also makes life difficult for the constructivist, because her point is that culture (a shared idea) constitutes interests. If interests and ideas are entirely different kinds of stuff, then it is not clear how they can mix and transmogrify one (mind) into another (body). Constructivism needs to overcome the Humean dualism of desire and belief. It can do so with an alternative, *cognitive* theory of desire.⁸¹ Simply put, we want what we want because of how we think about it. As we shall see, this need not vitiate intentional explanation, but it does suggest that there is more to the relationship between desire and belief than rationalism acknowledges.

Beyond the rationalist model

The Humean view that desire and belief are constitutionally unrelated is deeply embedded in rationalist discourse. It appeals to important intuitions in our everyday understandings of behavior,

⁷⁹ Smith (1987), Platts (1991).

⁸⁰ Howe (1994b: 179).

⁸¹ Howe (1994a).

and the structure of intentional explanation (desire *plus* belief) tacitly connotes it. On the other hand, there is a growing body of scholarship in philosophy, cognitive psychology, anthropology, and even economics which argues that desire is not separate from belief but constituted by it. This literature too appeals to important intuitions in everyday life. I discuss two different but related versions of this thesis, cognitive and deliberative. Judging from citations their advocates seem unaware of each other, and one seems to pose a deeper challenge to the traditional theory of intentional action than the other. But rather than assess their relationship, at this stage it seems more useful simply to present the two accounts and show how each links ideas to interests.

An important premise of the argument I make here is that we should care about how preferences are constituted. The premise comes from scientific realism and many rational choice scholars might disagree with it. For them, as for the empiricist anti-realists I discussed in chapter 2, "as if" assumptions about preferences are sufficient for theorizing. A sophisticated version of this argument is advanced by Debra Satz and John Ferejohn and it merits a response.⁸²

Satz and Ferejohn argue that rationalist explanations do not need to show that agents "really" are motivated by desires and beliefs, just that they act "as if" they are. If this is right, then the issue of what desires are made of is without substantive import, beside the point. Satz and Ferejohn are expressing a consensus among contemporary economists on an old debate about whether their discipline needs robust psychological assumptions about "utility." In the nineteenth century most economists thought it did. Systematized by Stanley Jevons, this view can be traced back to Bentham, who argued that utility was constituted by experiences,⁸³ and before that to Hobbes and Hume, who argued that "passions" were the source of desire. Beginning with seminal work by Paul Samuelson in the 1930s, however, economists have today largely abandoned this "internalist" view ("internal" because it referred to states of consciousness), because of its intractability, unrealistic psychology, and, importantly, appeal to unobservable causes.⁸⁴ Like behaviorists in psychology, rational choice theorists now take an "externalist" view, which treats desire in behavioral or operational terms *as* choice (revealed prefer-

ences) rather than as an unobservable cause of choice.⁸⁵ This is legitimate, Satz and Ferejohn argue, because in rationalist theory what explains outcomes are the structural constraints in a system, which will often have the same effects regardless of individual motivations (back to the macro-level aspect of rational choice above). The result is an instrumentalist reading of rationalism, in which no assumptions are made about the ontological status of desire and belief.⁸⁶ In a sense we are back to the epistemological anxiety discussed in chapter 2, which leads to a focus on what we can see and measure.

In a response to Satz and Ferejohn, Daniel Hausman defends the necessity of an internalist view of action,⁸⁷ on the grounds that even if the structure of a choice situation is highly constraining (as in a hotel fire), our explanation of the outcome (the occupants flee) depends on the accuracy of our assumptions about desires and beliefs. In the hotel fire example these assumptions are trivial (most people want to live and know that fire can kill them), and as such little will be gained by devoting much energy to refining them. But it remains the case that "the correctness of the explanation depends on their truth."⁸⁸ An adequate externalist story depends on an adequate internalist one.⁸⁹ Otherwise it is a mystery why the occupants flee, and we should want to know why. One reason is practical: structural theories that make false motivational assumptions may sometimes successfully predict outcomes, but if we ignore their falsity we will not know when they might fail us or how to revise them most efficiently.⁹⁰ From this standpoint, encouraging social scientists to ignore the truth of their assumptions is "bad methodological advice." Another reason we should care about motivation is philosophical: unlike the instrumentalism espoused by Satz and Ferejohn, in which the goal of science should be merely to "save the appearances," Hausman is a scientific realist who thinks that science should try to describe the causal mechanisms that generate appearances, and so we "must care whether the psychological claims employed in rational-choice explanations are true. Scientific realists about rational-choice theory must be internalists."⁹¹ Social scientists do not always need to worry about

⁸⁵ Sugden (1991: 757–761); on the relationship of rational choice to behaviorism see Homans (1990) and Rosenberg (1995).

⁸⁶ See Friedman (1953) and chapter 2, pp. 60–62.

⁸⁷ Hausman (1995).

⁸⁸ Ibid.: 101.

⁸⁹ Hollis and Sugden (1993: 26–32).

⁹⁰ Hausman (1995: 99).

⁹¹ Ibid.: 98.

⁸² Satz and Ferejohn (1994).

⁸³ Haslett (1990: 68–69), Kahneman and Varey (1991: 127–129).

⁸⁴ Cohen (1995).

the truth of their assumptions, but the question of how desire is constituted is not something that should be side-stepped completely.

The cognitive basis of desire

The first argument against a materialist view of interest is that interests are themselves cognitions or ideas. We find this thesis in two distinct bodies of scholarship, one in cultural anthropology, the other in philosophy.

Drawing on cognitive psychology, anthropologist Roy D'Andrade argues that motivations, desires, or interests should be seen as "schemas" (or "scripts," "frames," or "representations"), which are knowledge structures that "make possible the identification of objects and events."⁹² Many schemas are simply beliefs about the world that have no connection to desires. Other schemas are *goals* or desires that energize action. D'Andrade (p. 35) gives the example of a motivation for "achievement." Achievement implies a social standard about what counts as a legitimate aspiration – and as such is a cultural rather than material fact. Individuals who have a desire to achieve have internalized this standard as a cognitive schema. Similarly, in capitalist societies some people have a desire to get rich on the stock market. This is a schema which includes beliefs about the external world (how the market works, where it is going, etc.), and also constitutes its holder with a particular motivation that drives her behavior in that world. Symbolic interactionists would argue that many of these goal-schemas or interests are constituted by identities, which are schemas about the Self.⁹³ The identity or self-schema of professor, for example, constitutes an interest in teaching and publishing. Like other schemas, motivational schemas are organized hierarchically within the Self and so not all equally "salient,"⁹⁴ which is important in trying to explain what someone will do in a particular situation.

The important point is that none of these schemas is given by human nature. D'Andrade is careful to acknowledge that motivation is *partly* rooted in biological drives and as such is truly material.⁹⁵ Sometimes, as in the example of fleeing the hotel fire, these are more important in explaining action than culturally constituted schemas.

⁹² D'Andrade (1992: 28).

⁹³ For example, Morgan and Schwalbe (1990), Stryker (1991).

⁹⁴ Stryker (1980: 60–62). ⁹⁵ D'Andrade (1992: 31).

But biological drives explain few of the almost infinite goals human beings seem to be capable of pursuing. Most of these are learned through socialization. Those who would explain how desire is constituted, therefore, would do well to focus more on culture and its relationship to cognition than on biology.⁹⁶

Much the same conclusion is reached without much reference to cognitive psychology by R.B.K. Howe, who uses recent philosophical discussions to articulate a cognitive theory of desire.⁹⁷ Like D'Andrade Howe acknowledges a role for biological drives in the constitution of desire. Needs for food, water, reproduction and so on matter, and these are material. Yet Howe argues that even very primitive desires are mostly "directionless,"⁹⁸ and depend on beliefs about what is desirable to give them content. Beliefs define and direct material needs. It is the *perception* of value in an object that constitutes the motive to pursue it, not some intrinsic biological imperative. Such perceptions are learned, partly through interaction with nature (fire hurts; dirt tastes bad), in which case they have a materialist explanation, but mostly they are learned through socialization to culture. Desires always involve a mixture of biological drives and beliefs, with the importance of beliefs varying along a continuum from low (a desire for water when thirsty) to high (a desire to do the right thing).⁹⁹ These desire-constituting beliefs or cognitions have a different "direction of fit" with the world than the beliefs-"about" which figure on the belief side of the desire plus belief equation. To highlight their distinctiveness philosophers have dubbed them "desiderative beliefs." "Goal-schema" would do just as well.

The arguments of D'Andrade, Howe, and others concerned with the relationship between desire and belief refer mostly to individuals rather than groups.¹⁰⁰ I argue in chapter 5 that certain groups, including states, also have desires. This is an assumption of all state-centric IR theory, and one virtue of the cognitive approach to interests is that it is easier to defend this assumption than it is to defend it with a materialist approach, since states are not biological beings. Assuming for the moment that states have desires, let me illustrate the argument in this section with reference to the three state interests that

⁹⁶ For a good overview see DiMaggio (1997).

⁹⁷ Howe (1994a, b). See also Humberstone (1987), Smith (1987), Platts (1991), and Schueler (1995).

⁹⁸ Howe (1994a: 4). ⁹⁹ Howe (1994b: 182–183).

¹⁰⁰ Though see Clark (1994).

figured in the earlier discussion of the distribution of power: status quo, revisionist, and collectivist.

A status quo state is one that has no interest in conquering other states, redrawing boundaries, or changing the rules of the international system. It may attack another state to preempt a threat, but it has no intrinsic desire to infringe on other states' rights. How is this interest constituted? Undoubtedly part of the answer lies in basic material human needs for security and stability, but since all states are presumably subject to these needs and not all have status quo interests, this does not tell us enough. The cognitive theory of desire directs our attention to the schemas or representations through which status quo states define their interests.¹⁰¹ They may be hypothesized to have schemas as "satisfied" with their international position, as "law-abiding," as "members of a society of states," the rules of which are seen as "legitimate," and so on. These beliefs are not merely about an external world: they also constitute a certain identity and its relationship to that world, which in turn motivates action in certain directions. Status quo states have the interests they do, in other words, in virtue of their perceptions of the international order and their place within it as desirable, not because of brute material facts.

Revisionist states, in turn, have the desire to conquer others, seize part of their territory, and/or change the rules of the game. Human nature helps constitute these desires too, most likely in the form of self-esteem needs, but again this explains little. More significant will be self-schemas like "victim" or "master race," representations of Others as "infidels" or "evil empires," of the system as "illegitimate" or "threatening," war as "glorious" or "manly," and so on. These schemas are a function of culturally constituted cognitions, not biology.

Collectivist states have the desire to help those they identify with even when their own security is not directly threatened. Realist cynicism notwithstanding, biology surely plays a role here as well, since humans are social animals whose brains are hard-wired for "team play,"¹⁰² but this cannot explain why some states identify and some do not. The presence of certain schemas can: "we-ness," "friend," "special relationship," "doing the right thing," "regional policeman," and so on. In foreign policy discourse these "moral" schemas are often juxtaposed to "interests," as in the debate about US

intervention in the Bosnian civil war. One way to interpret President Clinton's speech to the American people justifying intervention is that it tried to define US "interests" in terms of the *belief* that Americans are the kind of people who do the right thing.

In chapters 4 and 6 I will argue that these interest-constituting ideas are in turn constituted by the *shared* ideas or culture of the international system. Here I am arguing that ideas at that macro level get into the heads of states and become interests at this other, more micro level of international structure.

The cognitive theory of desire violates the spirit but not the letter of the intentional theory of action. The traditional interpretation of intentionalism, following Hume, ruled out the hypothesis that beliefs could motivate, but nothing in the theory's propositional structure (the thin theory of rational choice) requires such an interpretation. It is perfectly consistent with the idea that beliefs and desires are distinct to hold that certain beliefs are about the external world and other beliefs constitute desires, and that the two play different explanatory roles. Desires are no less desires for being constituted by beliefs. As such, nothing said so far is inherently incompatible with rational choice theory, as long as rationalists concede that ideas play a larger role in explaining social action than is captured by the desire "plus" belief model. The resulting opening has been exploited by some rationalists in economics, who have modeled preferences as constituted by beliefs,¹⁰³ and others in IR, who have argued that state interests are affected by expectations about the environment.¹⁰⁴ Precisely because it is agnostic about what preferences are and where they come from, rational choice theory can be adapted to either an idealist or a materialist ontology.

The deliberative basis of desire

Cognitivism challenges the materialist view of desire, but it does not call into question the key assumption of the intentional theory, that desire and belief alone explain action. Desire still does all the motivational work, even if it has been reconceptualized as a kind of belief. An alternate argument for what explains action brings in reason or deliberation. Martin Hollis and G.F. Schueler, drawing from Kant,

¹⁰¹ Cf. Weldes (1996, 1999).

¹⁰² Wilson and Sober (1994: 601).

¹⁰³ For example, Cohen and Axelrod (1984), Geanakoplos, Pearce, and Stacchetti (1989).

¹⁰⁴ Niou and Ordeshook (1994), Powell (1994), Clark (1998).

argue that Reason or deliberation should be considered a third factor in the model: desire plus belief plus reason equals action.¹⁰⁵

The rationale for looking to a third factor stems from rational choice theory's paradoxically impoverished conception of "rational choice." Rationality is normally defined in instrumental terms as nothing more than having *consistent* desires and beliefs, and choice involves nothing more profound than their automatic enactment in behavior that maximizes expected utility. Rationalists rarely ask whether preferences are rational in the sense of justifiable, and often specifically abjure such assessments. "Rationality of action is always relative to the current desires of the agent,"¹⁰⁶ whatever their content. In this light humans differ from other animals only in the greater complexity of their desires and beliefs, not in their rationality. And indeed, experiments have shown that humans, rats, and pigeons are equally rational as defined by rational choice theory.¹⁰⁷ What is missing from this conception of rationality is any sense of deliberation, which goes back to the Humean model of man. In that model deliberation involves nothing more complicated than weighing up one's desires on a "grocer's scale,"¹⁰⁸ or doing a "vector analysis"¹⁰⁹ of their relative strength. There is no sense in the Humean model of Reason as a distinct faculty of mind that decides what desires to have, which to act upon, or even whether to act at all. The perhaps surprising result, therefore, is that rational choice theory is highly *deterministic*.¹¹⁰ This is seen in the many metaphors which its critics have coined to describe it. Schueler calls it the "blind forces" model of intentionality, in which agents (now rather mixing metaphors) are pushed and pulled by desire "rather in the way currents of air act on a falling leaf"; Hollis prefers the electronic imagery of agents as "throughputs" for desires and beliefs; Margaret Gilbert offers the mechanical metaphor of desire causing choice in "hydraulic" fashion; Harry Frankfurt calls people who do not reflect on their desires "wantons"; Amartya Sen calls them "rational fools."¹¹¹ For rhetorical punch none tops Hume, who argued that Reason "alone can never be a motive to any action of the will," and "is, and ought only to be the slave of the passions."¹¹² But

¹⁰⁵ Hollis (1987), Schueler (1995); also see Morse (1997).

¹⁰⁶ Hollis (1987: 74).

¹⁰⁷ Satz and Ferejohn (1994: 77 n. 19). ¹⁰⁸ Hollis (1987: 68).

¹⁰⁹ Schueler (1995: 169). ¹¹⁰ See Latsis (1972).

¹¹¹ See, respectively, Schueler (1995: 171), Hollis (1987: 68), Gilbert (1989: 419), Frankfurt (1971), and Sen (1977).

¹¹² Hume (1740/1978: 413, 415), quoted from Hollis (1987: 68) and Sugden (1991: 753).

all point to the fact that his model of man lacks the free, deliberating agent which one intuitively associates with "rational choice."

Indeed, whereas rational choice seems to be nothing more than a formalization of folk psychology – and on one level it is – on a closer read it is also somewhat out of sync with our common sense understandings of how and why people act. For example, the assumption that human beings do not reflect upon and choose their desires is hard to square with our intuitions about responsibility. If we are merely throughputs for desires and beliefs that we cannot control (since we are nothing *but* them), then how can we be held responsible for our actions?¹¹³ The reason we do not blame animals for their behavior is because we assume they lack the capacity for deliberation about their desires which would enable them to act differently than they do.¹¹⁴ Yet as we saw above in rational choice theory humans and animals are equally rational.

Another problematic intuition is that people often engage in practices of delayed gratification, "self-binding," and "character planning" which involve acting on behalf of desires they do not yet have.¹¹⁵ Rationalists may try to explain such behavior by introducing discounted future desires into the present, but this still raises the possibility of Reason shaping desire, which contradicts the Humean view.¹¹⁶

Finally, the desire/belief model ignores the sense in ordinary language that people can act against or in spite of their desires, that we can do something even though we "wanted" to do something else. Human beings are often deeply torn about whether to act on their desires, and sometimes restrain themselves because of Reason or morality. "External" rather than "internal" reasons sometimes prevail.¹¹⁷ Rationalists may try to explain such behavior as resolving a conflict between lower desires (e.g., be selfish) and higher desires (e.g., do the right thing), such that whatever an agent decides to do must have been what she really "wanted" to do: either lower or higher desires simply won out. But Schueler argues such an explanation conflates two senses of desire: "proper desires," which are in the head and can be acted against, and "pro attitudes," which are the

Hume's views on Reason were more complex and subtle than these famous passages suggest. For a good introduction see da Fonseca (1991: 81–116).

¹¹³ For literature on "moral autonomy" see Christman (1988).

¹¹⁴ Though see Evans (1987). ¹¹⁵ See Elster (1979, 1983b).

¹¹⁶ Hollis (1987: 85–86). ¹¹⁷ Ibid.: 74–94.

actual choices agents make. The distinction matters because pro attitudes are known through choices, not before, and as such cannot enter into an agent's own calculus about what to do.¹¹⁸ Reducing all deliberation to a weighing of conflicting desires, in other words, is a non-falsifiable proposition that cannot explain behavior. The desires that can truly explain behavior are proper desires, and in order to know how proper desires affect choices we need to bring in deliberation.

These intuitions all call into question the two-factor model of intentional action, but like the cognitivist argument, they can be made consistent with rational choice theory, if we detach it from its Humean moorings and view it as only a partial theory of action. In fact these intuitions suggest the fruitfulness of distinguishing two versions of intentional explanation, which Schueler calls the "blind forces" and "reflective" models.¹¹⁹ The former, corresponding to the traditional Humean view, treats human agency as "impulsive" and lacking meaningful deliberation. The latter, corresponding to a Kantian view, treats Reason as a third factor that deliberates about and helps choose interests.¹²⁰ While the blind forces model characterized rational choice scholarship for some time, rationalist social theory today is developing and strengthening its notions of deliberation and self-governance.¹²¹ Schueler sees an "enormous difference" between the two models (p. 186), but argues that the best description of a choice process in a given context, blind versus reflective, is always an empirical question. Moreover, since deliberation is a learned capacity, the balance between them for a given agent may change over time.

The addition of Reason to rational choice theory seems particularly apposite for IR scholarship. The philosophical literature on deliberative rationality concentrates on individuals. A strong case exists even in that context against the traditional, two-factor model of intentionality. But an emphasis on the role of deliberation in constituting interests seems even more appropriate for decision-making in groups. Often one of the most difficult tasks facing foreign policy decision-makers is figuring out what their interests *are*. This process does not typically consist of weighing competing interests on a "grocer's scale" of intensity, or even of aggregating the exogenously given preferences

¹¹⁸ Schueler (1995: 156–161).

¹¹⁹ *Ibid.*: 174–196; also see Hollis (1987) and Alker (1996: 207–237).

¹²⁰ Cf. Hirschman (1977, especially at 111–112).

¹²¹ See Sen (1977), Elster (1983b), Schelling (1984), Schmidt (1995), and Morse (1997).

of different individuals. It typically consists in a complex and highly contested process of discussion, persuasion, and framing of issues. In short, what goes on is collective deliberation about what their interests in a given situation should be. These deliberations do not take place in a vacuum, either domestic or international, but neither are they strictly determined by domestic or systemic structures. There are relatively few "hotel fires" in international politics. And sometimes deliberation can generate dramatic "preference reversals" even while structural conditions remain constant.¹²²

Such was arguably the case with Soviet New Thinking under Gorbachev. Those wedded to the blind forces model of intentional action will say that the Soviet leadership *had* to change its policies because of its declining relative power position. Certainly the economic and military pressures on the Soviet state were a crucial impetus for change. However, a structural pressure theory alone cannot explain the form the Soviet response took (ending the Cold War rather than intensifying repression) or its timing (the material decline had been going on for some time). And it also ignores the role that the leadership's realization that its own policies were part of the problem played in conditioning that response. Structural conditions did not force self-awareness on the Soviets. Soviet behavior changed because they redefined their interests as a result of having looked at their existing desires and beliefs self-critically. The reflective model of intentional explanation captures this process more naturally than the blind forces model.

This example also points to ways in which the cognitive and deliberative arguments may overlap. The principles informing Soviet "Reason" were not wholly independent of beliefs about the identity of the Soviet state, the feasibility of certain actions, and even about right and wrong. Deliberation about national interests takes place against the background of a shared national security discourse, in other words, which may substantially affect its content.¹²³ This blurring of Reason and belief is also evident in the philosophical literature. Howe, who does not make the Kantian argument that Reason is a distinct factor in intentional explanations, treats morality as a belief or schema. Schueler, who does make the Kantian argument, places moral

¹²² For a thought-provoking discussion of the implications of preference reversals for our conventional understandings of "preference," which includes the one above, see Slovic (1995).

¹²³ Campbell (1992), Weldes (1996, 1999).

considerations under the heading of Reason. My own inclinations lie with Schueler because the cognitive theory alone, with its continued reliance on just desire and belief to explain action, does not escape the determinism of rational choice theory. But the relationship between the two idealist critiques of materialist theories of desire is complicated and need not concern us here.

Toward a rump materialism II

The overlap between the cognitive and deliberative critiques suggests a general proposition about the relationship between interests and ideas: "interests are beliefs about how to meet needs."¹²⁴ Since this depends on a distinction between interests and needs,¹²⁵ let me first say a few words about the latter and then return to interests. As in my concluding remarks about power, having now taken the idealist line that interests are constituted mostly by ideas, in this section I turn around and defend the rump materialist view that they nevertheless must ultimately hook on to a material ground, human nature.

Needs refer to the functional reproduction requirements of a particular kind of agent, what some would call "objective interests."¹²⁶ Two types of needs may be discerned: identity needs and material needs. Identity needs are as variable as the identities they sustain, which is to say practically infinite. To reproduce the identity of a state a group needs to sustain a monopoly on the legitimate use of violence in their territory. To reproduce the identity of a professor an individual needs to teach. In both cases these needs reflect the internal and external structures that constitute these actors as social kinds. There is no guarantee identity needs will be translated into appropriate beliefs about how to meet them, which is to say into (subjective) *interests*, but if they are not translated then the agents they constitute will not survive. Identity needs are ultimately a matter of individual and social cognitions rather than biology. They are still real and objective, but given that they are not material to focus on them here would do little to clarify the role of materialism. So let me turn to the material needs stemming from human nature and show just what exactly is a material basis for desire.

Scientific realism assumes that human beings are self-organizing

¹²⁴ Rosenberg (1992: 167).

¹²⁵ See Doyal and Gough (1984).

¹²⁶ McCullagh (1991).

natural kinds with material reproduction requirements. All animals have such requirements. Material needs are no guarantee that individuals will try to meet them (people do commit suicide), but it seems likely that were humans not predisposed to meet their needs we would never have survived evolution. The content of this predisposition is "human nature." Radical constructivists might deny the existence, or at least social significance, of biological needs. But despite its well-intentioned resistance to biological determinism, there is an anthropic exceptionalism or human chauvinism in the radical view that is hard to justify from the standpoint of evolutionary theory. It is impossible to explain social action without making at least implicit assumptions about human nature, since, without it, it is hard to explain why our bodies move at all, let alone their direction or resistance to societal pressures.¹²⁷ If this is right, then even postmodernists have a theory of human nature. I shall not examine competing views of human nature here, but if all sociologies presuppose one there is not much point dodging the issue either.

Let me therefore stipulate the following rump materialist "theory" of human nature. Unlike the open-ended list of identity needs, it posits just five material needs. These are needs of individuals, not groups. Groups also have needs, but since they do not have bodies these will be identity needs which cannot be reduced to the material needs of their members, even though they help meet the latter (see chapter 5). Material needs may generate contradictory imperatives and thus practices, but they vary in importance and people will generally – though not always – try to meet their more fundamental needs first. In roughly descending order of importance:¹²⁸

- 1 *Physical security*: human beings need food, water, and sleep to sustain their bodies, and protection from threats to their physical integrity. Fear of death comes under this heading.
- 2 *Ontological security*: human beings need relatively stable expectations about the natural and especially social world around them. Along with the need for physical security, this pushes human beings in a conservative, homeostatic direction, and to seek out recognition of their standing from society.

¹²⁷ Carveth (1982: 202).

¹²⁸ This list combines elements from Giddens (1984), Turner (1988), Johnson (1990), Maslow (see Davies, 1991), and Honneth (1996).

- 3 *Sociation*: human beings are social animals who need contact with each other. Needs for love and group membership are met through sociation.
- 4 *Self-esteem*: human beings need to feel good about themselves. This is achieved primarily through social relationships, and as such its content can vary hugely, including "needs" for honor, glory, achievement, recognition (again), power, group membership (again), and so on.
- 5 *Transcendence*: human beings need to grow, develop, and improve their life condition. This is a source of creativity and innovation, and of efforts to remake their material circumstances.

In the last analysis the energy that human beings expend in their lives stems from efforts to meet these material needs, and people will define their interests in ways that facilitate doing so in the material and cultural environments in which they find themselves. When needs are met people experience the emotion of satisfaction. When needs are not met we experience anxiety, fear, or frustration, which depending on the circumstances will motivate us to redouble our efforts, to change our interests, or to engage in aggression. Thus, in contrast to Classical Realists who would posit fear, insecurity, or aggression as essential parts of human nature, I am suggesting these feelings are effects of unmet needs and therefore contingent. The effort to prevent the fear and anxiety associated with unmet needs is part of human nature, but fear and anxiety themselves are socially constructed.

Regardless of the truth of this particular "theory" of human nature, rump materialism is an ontological argument that we need some such theory to explain human behavior. Ironically, Neorealists seem as uncomfortable with this suggestion as radical constructivists, preferring to ground their theory on the "structural" materialism of power rather than the "reductionist" materialism of human nature. Human nature cannot be avoided, however, and the assumptions we make about it will condition our theorizing about world politics. Like power, interests are not ideas *all* the way down. This is a significant idealist concession to materialism, but the two are not contradictory. Biological realism is compatible with social construction.¹²⁹ The ques-

tion is to *what extent* does biology constitute interests? Perhaps thinking that it cannot or need not be answered, systemic IR scholars have largely avoided this question in recent decades, but with the emergence of sociobiology there is now the potential for a renewed and fruitful discussion. Sociobiologists would say biology matters quite a lot in the constitution of interests,¹³⁰ as would perhaps most Classical Realists. Even Neorealists, when necessary to sustain their pessimism about anarchy, will fall back on the view that human nature is inherently selfish or power-seeking.¹³¹ In contrast, even though the kind of constructivism I favor is thin, in my view biology matters relatively little. Human nature does not tell us whether people are good or bad, aggressive or pacific, power-seeking or power-conferring, even selfish or altruistic. These are all socially contingent, not materially essential. Much more than other animals, human behavior is underdetermined by our nature, a fact attested to by the remarkable variety of cultural forms we have created. In developing this hypothesis we should not forget that human beings are animals whose material needs are a key constituting element of their interests, but in the end their interests are mostly a function of their ideas, not their genes.

Let me conclude with three virtues of an idealist approach to the study of interests in IR. First, and most important, it suggests a program of empirical research for studying the content of real world state interests. Most traditions of IR theory rely on intentional explanations of action, and as such need a model of state interests. In practice mainstream IR scholars typically assume a model. This is perfectly legitimate for certain purposes, but it is nevertheless striking just how little empirical research has been done investigating what kinds of interests state actors actually have.¹³² Perhaps this is because everyone "knows" that states are egoists who want power (and wealth?, or security?), or because the influence of rationalism on the field has discouraged the empirical study of preferences, but it might also reflect the fact that materialist social theory offers little guidance about how exactly to find and study interests, especially in a corporate person like the state. By hypothesizing that interests are constituted by ideas, idealism suggests that schema theory and attention to

¹³⁰ Witt (1991), Maryanski and Turner (1992).

¹³¹ For example, Fischer (1992: 465).

¹³² Krasner (1978) was for long an important exception. Today also see Zürn (1997) and Kimura and Welch (1998).

¹²⁹ Sabini and Schulkin (1994), Mead (1934).

deliberation processes – suitably adjusted for the fact that states have collective rather than individual cognitions – might prove to be fruitful approaches to this problem.¹³³

Second, and by extension, an idealist approach to interests also suggests ways to operationalize the relationship between cognition (agency) and culture (structure). In social (and IR) theory it has become commonplace to describe action as culturally or discursively structured, but rarely is a mechanism supplied through which this effect might actually work.¹³⁴ Somehow it is thought to be enough to point to the existence of cultural norms and corresponding behavior, without showing how norms get inside actors' heads to motivate actions. The materialist theory of interests may help explain this neglect, since it makes it difficult to see how an ideational phenomenon like culture could affect a material phenomenon like interests. Recognizing that interests are constituted by ideas removes the problem of mixing two kinds of "stuff." In IR this points toward a potentially fruitful dialogue between cognitive theories of foreign policy and cultural theories of structure, perhaps organized around the concept of foreign policy "role" (see chapters 4 and 6).

Finally, this approach suggests new possibilities for foreign policy and systemic change. In raising this issue it should be emphasized that saying that interests are made of ideas does not mean they easily can be changed in any given context. Idealism is not utopianism, and it is often harder to change someone's mind than their behavior. As such, ironically enough materialists may sometimes have a rosier view of the future than idealists, as in Waltz's view that controlled nuclear proliferation can cause system stability.¹³⁵ However, to the extent that interests are constituted by beliefs we can have more hope of changing them than we could if they simply reflected human nature (short of genetic engineering). It may be difficult for an actor to change its interests if the beliefs that constitute them are part of a culture that simultaneously constitutes the interests of other actors. This helps explain why cultures tend to reproduce themselves once created. But the fact remains that if interests are made of ideas, then discursive processes of deliberation, learning, and negotiation are

¹³³ See, for example, D'Andrade and Strauss, eds. (1992), Schneider and Angelmar (1993), and Welles (1999).

¹³⁴ D'Andrade (1992: 41). ¹³⁵ Waltz (1990).

potential vehicles of foreign policy and even structural change that would be neglected by a materialist approach.

Conclusion

The argument of this chapter has been that the meaning of the distribution of power in international politics is constituted in important part by the distribution of interests, and that the content of interests are in turn constituted in important part by ideas. The constitutive as opposed to causal nature of this claim bears emphasis. The claim is *not* that ideas are more important than power and interest, or that they are autonomous from power and interest. Power and interest are just as important and determining as before. The claim is rather that power and interest have the effects they do in virtue of the ideas that make them up. Power and interest explanations *presuppose* ideas, and to that extent are not rivals to ideational explanations at all. My claim is therefore different than the Neoliberal argument that a substantial proportion of state action can be explained by ideas and institutions rather than power and interest. That treats ideas in causal terms which, while important, is not enough. The issue of "how" ideas matter is not limited to their causal effects.¹³⁶ They also matter insofar as they constitute the "material base" in the first place, that is, insofar as it is "ideas all the way down."

An argument that power and interest are just as important as before, but constituted more by ideas than material forces, inevitably raises the question, "so what?" If the balance of variables has not changed, what difference does this make to our understanding of international politics? Part II of this book is one answer to this question. But let me answer for now in programmatic terms by proposing a rule of thumb for idealists: when confronted by ostensibly "material" explanations, always inquire into the discursive conditions which make them work. When Neorealists offer multipolarity as an explanation for war, inquire into the discursive conditions that constitute the poles as enemies rather than friends. When Liberals offer economic interdependence as an explanation for peace, inquire into the discursive conditions that constitute states with identities that care about free trade and economic growth. When Marxists offer

¹³⁶ Cf. Goldstein and Keohane (1993: 6).

capitalism as an explanation for state forms, inquire into the discursive conditions that constitute capitalist relations of production. And so on. Enmity, interdependence, and capitalism are to a large extent cultural forms, and to that extent materialist explanations that presuppose those forms will be vulnerable to the kind of idealist critique featured in this chapter.

This is not to say that we should never treat cultural contexts as given, within which materialist explanations may be compelling, but in doing so we should recognize that the latter acquire their causal powers only in virtue of the contexts of meaning which make them what they are. Nor, on the other hand, is this to say that material forces like human nature, technology, or geography play no role in state action whatsoever. However, the materialist explanations offered above go well beyond such factors, in effect "cheating" on the materialism-idealism test by building implicit cultural elements into their claims. Only after we have stripped the discursive conditions of possibility from those claims will we know what material forces can really do.¹³⁷

This argument tries to change the terms of the materialism-idealism debate in social theory by reducing "materialism" from its traditional, expansive definition focusing on the mode of production (or destruction), to a stricter, rump definition focusing on materiality per se.¹³⁸ This is not definitional sleight of hand, but an attempt to get at issues that are obscured in the traditional base-superstructure model. The key here is recognizing that materiality is not the same thing as objectivity. Cultural phenomena are just as objective, just as constraining, just as *real* as power and interest. Idealist social theory is not about denying the existence of the real world. The point is that the real world consists of a lot more than material forces *as such*. Unlike a potentially more radical constructivist position I do not deny the existence and independent causal powers of those forces, but I do think they are less important and interesting than the contexts of meaning that human beings construct around them.

Finally, this reframing of the issue casts new light on the Neorealist-Neoliberal debate. In my view, Neoliberals are caught in a Realist

¹³⁷ For a productive attempt to articulate a stricter materialist view of international politics see Brooks (2000).

¹³⁸ Bimber (1994) makes an analogous effort to differentiate meanings of technological determinism, some of which he argues are not technological determinism at all, but socio-cultural arguments about how technology gets used.

trap. It is the same trap that structural Marxists like Louis Althusser and Nicos Poulantzas were caught in when they tried to show, against orthodox Marxists, that the superstructure was "relatively autonomous" from its base.¹³⁹ Structural Marxists conceded primary explanatory importance to the mode of production (material base), but tried to show that institutional and ideological superstructures were important intervening variables. This theory ultimately failed, however, because of the inability to make coherent the argument that the superstructure was "relatively autonomous" while the material base remained still "determinant in the last instance."¹⁴⁰ (Interestingly, with the failure of structural Marxism many erstwhile adherents became post-structuralists, a move not unlike what happened in the 1980s in IR.) As in the case of structural Marxists, Neoliberals have done important work showing that by itself the material base (here, power and interest) cannot explain international outcomes by itself, but by conceding the base to Neorealists they have nevertheless exposed themselves to the same problem. This trap underlies Mearsheimer's argument that Neoliberals are tacit Realists; structural Marxists, after all, were still Marxists.¹⁴¹ From Mearsheimer's perspective and mine, in other words, Neoliberals face a hard choice: either acknowledge the ultimately Realist character of their theory (because it buys into the base-superstructure interpretation of materialism) and deal with the problems of sustaining an independent theoretical position using a "relative autonomy" thesis, or refuse the Realist trap by problematizing the "materialist" nature of power and interest explanations from the start. Either way, in the end there can only be two possibilities, materialist and idealist, because there are only two kinds of stuff in the world, material and ideational.

Throughout this chapter I have used the language of ideas and the term idealism to make the case against materialist approaches to structure. This permitted economy of expression, but it might have suggested that I advocate a subjectivist approach to social theory in which all that matters is how individual agents perceive the world, or a voluntarist one in which agents are thought to be free to choose any ideas they wish. I advocate neither. How agents perceive the world is important in explaining their actions, and they always have an

¹³⁹ Althusser (1970), Poulantzas (1975).

¹⁴⁰ See Hall (1977) and Hirst (1977).

¹⁴¹ Mearsheimer (1994/1995). The fact that regime theory, the forerunner of what became known as Neoliberalism, originally emerged from a Realist perspective is evidence for this line of reasoning. On the limits of Realism see Krasner (1983b).

element of choice in defining their identities and interests. However, in addition to idealism, a key feature of constructivism is holism or structuralism, the view that social structures have effects that cannot be reduced to agents and their interactions. Among these effects is the shaping of identities and interests, which are conditioned by discursive formations – by the *distribution* of ideas in the system – as well as by material forces, and as such are not formed in a vacuum. I have so far largely ignored the effects of this distribution, as well as the senses in which it might be structured. It is to these issues that I now turn.

4 Structure, agency, and culture

In chapter 3 I used the language of ideas to argue against a materialist approach to the study of structure. As I see it, however, social constructivism is not just about idealism, it is also about structuralism or holism. Structures have effects not reducible to agents. With that in mind this chapter looks at the structure of ideas in the system and asks: What does it mean to say that there is an ideational structure in a system? And what effects can such a structure have?

The structure of any social system will contain three elements: material conditions, interests, and ideas. Although related these elements are also in some sense distinct and play different roles in explanation. The significance of material conditions is constituted in part by interests, but they are not the same thing. Oil does not have the same kind of causal powers as an interest in the status quo. Similarly, interests are constituted in part by ideas, but they are not the same thing. The ideas constituting an interest in revisionism do not have the same kind of causal powers as the belief that other states obey international law. These distinctions mean that it may be useful for analytical purposes to treat the distributions of the three elements as separate “structures” (material structure, structure of interests, ideational structure). If we do so, however, it is important to remember that they are always articulated and equally necessary to explain social outcomes. Without ideas there are no interests, without interests there are no meaningful material conditions, without material conditions there is no reality at all. In the end for any given social system there is just structure, in the singular. The task of structural theorizing ultimately must be to show how the elements of a system fit together into some kind of whole.

Even if social structures always contain all three elements, it is